

17, The Situation in Northern India

The situation in India remains significantly more opaque. This is primarily dictated by the agonizing scarcity of historical documentary records and the inherent complexity of the geopolitical landscape across the subcontinent. Although various regions inevitably interacted, they simultaneously maintained relatively independent developmental trajectories, particularly concerning the divide between Southern and Northern India.

Despite this, it is universally acknowledged that the Gupta Dynasty (笈多王朝) represents the absolute zenith of **classical India**. This consensus is undeniably corroborated by substantial evidence, the most paramount of which is the glaring surge in social mobility.

During India's transition from the Mahajanapadas period (列国时期 / Period of the Great Realms) to a **classical society** (古典社会), the rigidly calcified caste system prescribed by Brahmanism had already begun to loosen. The rulers of the Nanda (难陀王朝) and Maurya Dynasties (孔雀王朝) were highly likely not born into the Kshatriya (刹帝利) caste, and may have even originated from humble origins—not to mention the foreign (*e.g.*, *Hellenistic*) ruling families that emerged in the Northwest.

During the reign of the Gupta Dynasty, the *Puranas* (往事书) began to abandon the strict doctrinal insistence—previously enshrined in the *Manusmriti* (摩奴法典 / Laws of Manu)—that kings must inherently be born as Kshatriyas. Now, what dictated royal authority was the sheer extent of territory a ruler could actively control, utterly regardless of their origins or the methods employed to seize the throne. **The status of a Kshatriya mutated from an ascribed hereditary tier into an achieved status.**

The social status of merchants and certain artisans was concurrently elevating, a phenomenon directly reflecting the prosperity of the **commodity economy** (商品经济) and handicraft industries characteristic of a **classical empire** (古典帝国).

Another demographic experiencing a glaring elevation in status was the scribes, known in India as the **Kayasthas** (卡雅斯塔). This group first emerged in a **classical empire** located in Northwestern India that existed concurrently with Rome, Parthia, and the Han Dynasty—an empire referred to in Chinese records as the Kushan Empire (贵霜帝国). Serving the royal household and participating in state administration across domains such as jurisprudence, literature, and accounting, the astronomical growth in both the numbers and prestige of the *Kayasthas* glaringly reflected the expansion of the bureaucratic system.

Indian society's schizophrenic categorization of the *Kayasthas*' identity further perfectly illustrates this point. Sometimes they were revered as Kshatriyas, yet at other times, they were vilified as the product of an "illicit union" between Brahmins and Shudras (首陀罗). These profoundly fascinating contradictions perfectly mirror the fundamental characteristics of a classical bureaucratic system. The *Kayasthas* who rose to prominence in classical India were highly likely exceptionally intelligent and literate individuals sourced from across various castes. However, when they appeared before the ruled masses as executors of state power and imperial will, they were inherently perceived as a ruling class comparable to Kshatriyas. Conversely, when they appeared before the entrenched Brahmin aristocracy merely as servants of the ruler, they were scorned as impure.

Simultaneously, the status of other demographics plummeted. To the northwest of the Gupta Dynasty's center of power, near Delhi, certain ancient regions of *Aryavarta* (雅利安伐尔塔 / the abode of the noble ones) situated in the Yamuna-Ganges basin suffered from catastrophic stigmatization. They were denigrated as *mleccha-desa* (蔑戾车—提舍)—an immutable, deeply stigmatizing designation applied to the lands inhabited by "low-born" barbarians and forest-dwelling tribes. As the initial foothold of the Aryans in India, the fact that this modern-day northwestern frontier experienced such a glaring degradation in status somehow inversely reflected the relentless concentration of power and wealth into a handful of massive metropolises at the empire's core. (*The aforementioned data is primarily derived from Burton Stein's "A History of India"*).

Regarding the *Arthashastra* (《政事论》 / also translated into Chinese as 《利论》), although traditionally attributed to Kautilya (考底利耶), contemporary scholars increasingly lean toward the consensus that it is a text fundamentally compiled several centuries AD. This monumental work explicitly articulated demands to prohibit the enslavement of freemen, stipulated conditions for the manumission of slaves, and vehemently advocated replacing the slavery system with a tenancy system (租佃制). (The final point is manifested as the administrative system's heavy reliance on the systems of tenancy and sharecropping, as described in this work.) Similarly, in Faxian's (法显) *Record of Buddhist Kingdoms* (《佛国记》), there are explicit accounts of dependent peasant households bound to the land being transferred alongside the transfer of land ownership. **These historical realities undeniably reflect the aggressive development of feudal relations of production and feudal land tenure systems.**

What particularly shocks Chinese readers is that the myriad statecraft philosophies and governance measures articulated in the *Arthashastra* are virtually identical to the policies implemented by the Qin and Han empires. **The profound structural similarities among classical empires are glaringly evident.**

The explosive prosperity of academic and civilizational achievements characteristic of a classical dynasty identically manifested during this epoch. The two monumental epics, the *Mahabharata* (《摩诃婆罗多》) and the *Ramayana* (《罗摩衍那》), were definitively canonized during this period. The Nalanda mahavihara (那烂陀寺)—the absolute epicenter of Mahayana Buddhism—was established under the ferocious patronage of Kumaragupta I (鸠摩罗笈多一世), exerting a colossal impact on the entirety of Northern Buddhism (北传佛教). Monarchs aggressively patronized the arts within their courts, driving Sanskrit literary creation and Sanskrit drama (梵剧) to their absolute zenith. Mathematics, astronomy, and physics also achieved monumental breakthroughs, with the most iconic being the maturation of what is now known as the "Hindu-Arabic" numeral system (阿拉伯数字) and the invention of the cotton gin (轧棉机).

While India and Iran sequentially basked in the glory of their respective **classical eras (classical period/古典时代)**, China and Rome had already successively met their apocalyptic fates, collapsing amidst the process of **feudalization** (封建化). This catastrophic domino effect instigated the "Great Migration of Peoples" (民族大迁徙) across the entire Eurasian landmass, most notably driving the massive east-to-west movement of nomadic tribes.

Compared to the invaders plunging down from the northwest, India historically found itself at a severe disadvantage in military technology. During the zenith of **classical India**, the nomads of the

northwest were insufficient to shake the foundations of the empire. However, the exact moment **feudalization** commenced, resisting these barbarians—whom the Chinese historical records referred to as the *Huna* (匈奴人 / Hephthalites / White Huns)—became increasingly excruciating, ultimately resulting in the obliteration of the Gupta Dynasty.

King Harsha (戒日王), the final indigenous monarch to establish hegemony over Northern India, originated from the Rajputs (拉杰普特人). This specific demographic was forged through the amalgamation of the indigenous populace with multiple waves of foreign invaders entering the Indian subcontinent, beginning with the Greeks. Through ceaseless border conflicts, they honed a fierce collective identity, worshipped martial prowess, and became hyper-**feudalized** (*relative, of course, to other communities on the subcontinent*). They could appropriately be crowned as the "**Samurai of India**".

During King Harsha's reign, the virulent development of the **feudal system** was already glaringly obvious. The king himself massively granted hereditary land fiefs to both ecclesiastical and secular grand aristocrats in direct exchange for their political and military allegiance. Consequently, Harsha's empire disintegrated instantaneously upon his death. Northern India plunged straight into the era of warlord chaos that universally ensues following **feudalization**, and the power of the Rajputs aggressively expanded across the North. Only the Pala Empire (波罗王朝) in eastern Bengal managed to artificially prolong the survival of **classical society**—simply because its socio-historical progression lagged significantly behind.

In a **feudalized** India, caste status no longer derived from bloodline inheritance; it was dictated exclusively by sheer martial violence. **This is precisely one of the absolute core characteristics of a feudal society.**

From a retrospective viewpoint, the **feudalization** of Northern India possessed monumental historical significance. The conquests of India orchestrated by the Arab Empire were violently halted at the Sindh region (信德地区). Even centuries later, when Turkic Muslims fundamentally breached the subcontinent in massive invasions, and the Indians were temporarily subjugated due to martial inferiority, **the Muslims were fundamentally incapable of propagating their own feudal system as they had seamlessly done in other regions.**

This was because the indigenous ruling class—who fiercely retained their Indian religion and culture—still comprehensively dominated social production across Northern India. This indestructible reality laid the absolute foundation for India ultimately reverting to a predominantly Hindu nation today. (*Naturally, the crucial prerequisite for this was that Hinduism at the time had already completed its mutation from an early religion, like Brahmanism, into a genuine **feudalized religion** (封建宗教), successfully securing an unshakeable ecological niche. In regions where this process never occurred—such as Iran—Zoroastrianism was fundamentally eradicated by Islam, regardless of the fact that what survived was an "Iranianized" version of Islam.*)

Right up until the end of the 17th century, the relentless rebellions spearheaded by the Rajputs against the Mughal Empire (莫卧儿帝国) remained the lethal catalyst that triggered the collapse of that empire.

However, we absolutely must not overlook the following agonizing problem: the protracted, institutionalized confrontation between the Islamic conquerors and the indigenous Indian ruling

class across Northern India undeniably could not contribute any positive momentum to the *feudalization* process.

The former (Islamic conquerors) found it agonizingly difficult to acquire further land property rights, especially absolute ownership; they were perpetually forced to stall at the superficial level of holding tax-collection rights and appointing tax farmers (包税人). The latter (indigenous Hindu lords) lost their political paramountcy and were fundamentally incapable of executing their ruling authority according to their own will.

This paralyzing deadlock, combined with India's terrifyingly vast "internal frontiers" (内部边疆) teeming with a colossal population, mutated into the ultimate anchor dragging down and severely retarding the *feudalization* process in Northern India.

17，北印度的情况

印度的情况要不明朗许多，这是因为文献记载稀少和次大陆政治形势本身复杂所导致的，各个地区虽然相互影响，但是又有相对独立的发展历程，特别是在南印度和北印度之间。尽管如此，人们普遍认为笈多王朝是古典印度的顶峰，这确实得到了不少证据的证明，其中最重要的是社会流动性的显著增长。在印度从列国时期向古典社会过渡的时候，婆罗门教所规定的种姓制度就已经开始发生松动，难陀王朝和孔雀王朝的统治者就极可能并非出身于刹帝利种姓，甚至出身低微，更不要提在西北方出现的外国（例如希腊化的）统治者家族了。在笈多王朝统治时期，往事书开始不再坚持《摩奴法典》中国王生来就必须是刹帝利的说法，现在决定王权的是统治者能实际统治多少领土，而无论其出身如何，以什么方式取得江山。刹帝利的地位变成了一种成就，而不是一种归属的等级。商人和某些工匠的社会地位也在提升，这反映了古典帝国商品经济和手工业的发达。另一个地位明显提升的群体是抄写员，在印度被称为“卡雅斯塔”（kayasthas），这个群体最早出现在印度西北方一个与罗马、安息和汉朝并立的古典帝国，中国的文献中称之为贵霜帝国。作为为皇室服务，在法律，文学，会计等等领域参与国家行政的群体，其数量和声望的与日俱增显然反映了官僚体制的扩大。印度社会对卡雅斯塔的身份定位也说明了这一点，他们有的时候被视为刹帝利，有的时候又被描述为婆罗门和首陀罗“非法结合”的产物。这些观点非常有趣地反映了古典官僚体制的特征，在古典印度兴起的卡雅斯塔大概率来自各个种姓中识字并且聪明伶俐的人，只不过当他们作为国家权力和意志的执行者出现在被统治者面前时，就会被视为刹帝利这样的统治阶层；当他们作为统治者的仆从出现在婆罗门贵族面前时，就会被视为不洁的人。

与此同时，另一些人的地位有所下降，在笈多王朝统治中心西北方德里附近亚穆尔河—恒河流域中某些古老的雅利安伐尔塔（Aryavarta）地区遭到非常严重的鄙视蔑戾车—提舍（mleccha-desa），这是一种对于外国人和森林民这样的低贱族群及其居住土地不可更改的污名化称号。作为雅利安人在印度最早的落脚点，现在的西北边境，其地位如此明显地下降某种意义上权势和财富向统治中心的几个大城市的集中。（以上资料主要采自伯顿斯坦的《印度文明史》）《政事论》（现在汉语也翻译为《利论》）虽然在传统上被认为是考底利耶所作，不过现在学者们似乎更倾向于这是公元之后的几个世纪才出现的作品。这篇作品提出了不要把自由民变为奴隶的要求，制定释放奴隶的条件，并且呼吁以租佃制代替奴隶制度（最后一点体现为书中描述的行政管理体系对租佃制和分成制的高度依赖）。在法显的《佛国记》中也有依附在土地上的民户随土地（所有权）转移的现象，这些事实无疑反映了封建生产关系和土地制度的发展。特别令中国人感到震惊的是，《利论》这本书的许多治国观点与秦汉帝国采取的措施如出一辙，古典帝国的相似性可见一斑。古典王朝的学术和文明成果繁荣同样明显地出现了，《摩诃婆罗多》和《罗摩衍那》两部史诗在这个时期定型。大乘佛教的中心那烂陀寺在鸠摩罗笈多一世的支持下建立起来，对整个北传佛教产生了巨大的影响。君主在宫廷中赞助艺术，梵文文学创作和梵剧艺术达到顶峰。数学，

天文学和物理学也取得了很大发展，最具代表性的就是现在被称为“阿拉伯”数字系统的成熟以及轧棉机的发明。

在印度和伊朗相继享受古典时代的荣光时，中国和罗马已经先后迎来了在封建化过程中崩溃的命运，这策动了整个欧亚大陆的民族大迁徙，特别是游牧民族自东向西的大范围运动。相对于来自西北方向的入侵者，印度在军事技术上往往处于劣势。在古典印度处于鼎盛的年代，西北方的游牧民尚且不足以动摇这个帝国，但是当封建化开始之后，抵御这些被中国称为匈奴人（huna）的蛮族就变得越来越困难，笈多王朝因此覆灭。最后一个在北印度建立霸权的本土君主戒日王出身于拉杰普特人（Rajput），这个群体是由从希腊人开始的多批进入印度大陆的外族与当地居民融合形成的，他们在常年的边境冲突中磨炼出了自我认同，崇尚武艺并且高度封建化（当然是跟印度次大陆的其他社群相比），可以称作是“印度的武士”。在戒日王统治时期，封建制度的发展就已经极为明显，他本人就对于教俗大贵族大量封赐世袭土地换取政治和军事效忠。戒日王的帝国在他死之后马上就瓦解了，北印度进入了封建化之后普遍出现的军阀混战年代，拉杰普特人的势力在北印度迅速扩张，只有东方孟加拉国的波罗王朝因为社会历史进程较晚而将古典社会存续了下去。在封建化的印度，种姓地位不来源于血缘的继承，而仅仅取决于武力，这也正是封建社会的主要特征之一。

北印度的封建化在日后看来极具意义，阿拉伯帝国组织的对于印度的征服被终止在信德地区。日后即使是突厥穆斯林大举突入的时候，印度人虽然因为武力上的劣势被暂时征服，然而穆斯林根本无法同其他地区一样推广其封建制度。因为保有印度宗教和文化的本国统治阶级仍然在北印度广泛主导了社会生产，这就为印度最终在现在恢复为一个印度教徒占大头的国家奠定了基础。（当然这样的前提是当时的印度教已经完成了从婆罗门教这样的早期宗教到封建宗教的转变，获得了稳定的生态位。在没有发生这个过程的地方，例如伊朗，拜火教无论如何都被伊斯兰教基本清除了，哪怕剩下的是“伊朗化的”伊斯兰教）直到 17 世纪末，拉杰普特人对于莫卧儿帝国的反抗依然构成了这个帝国垮台的导火索。不过我们确实不应该忽视这样一个问题，伊斯兰征服者和印度本土统治阶级在北印度的长期对立，显然不可能对于封建化进程有什么正向意义。前者难以获得更多土地产权特别是所有权，只能停留在税收权和任命包税人这个层次；后者在政治上失去了主导地位，无法按照自己的意志贯彻统治权。它和印度广阔的，拥有庞大人口的内部边疆一起成为拖慢北印度封建化进程的重要因素。